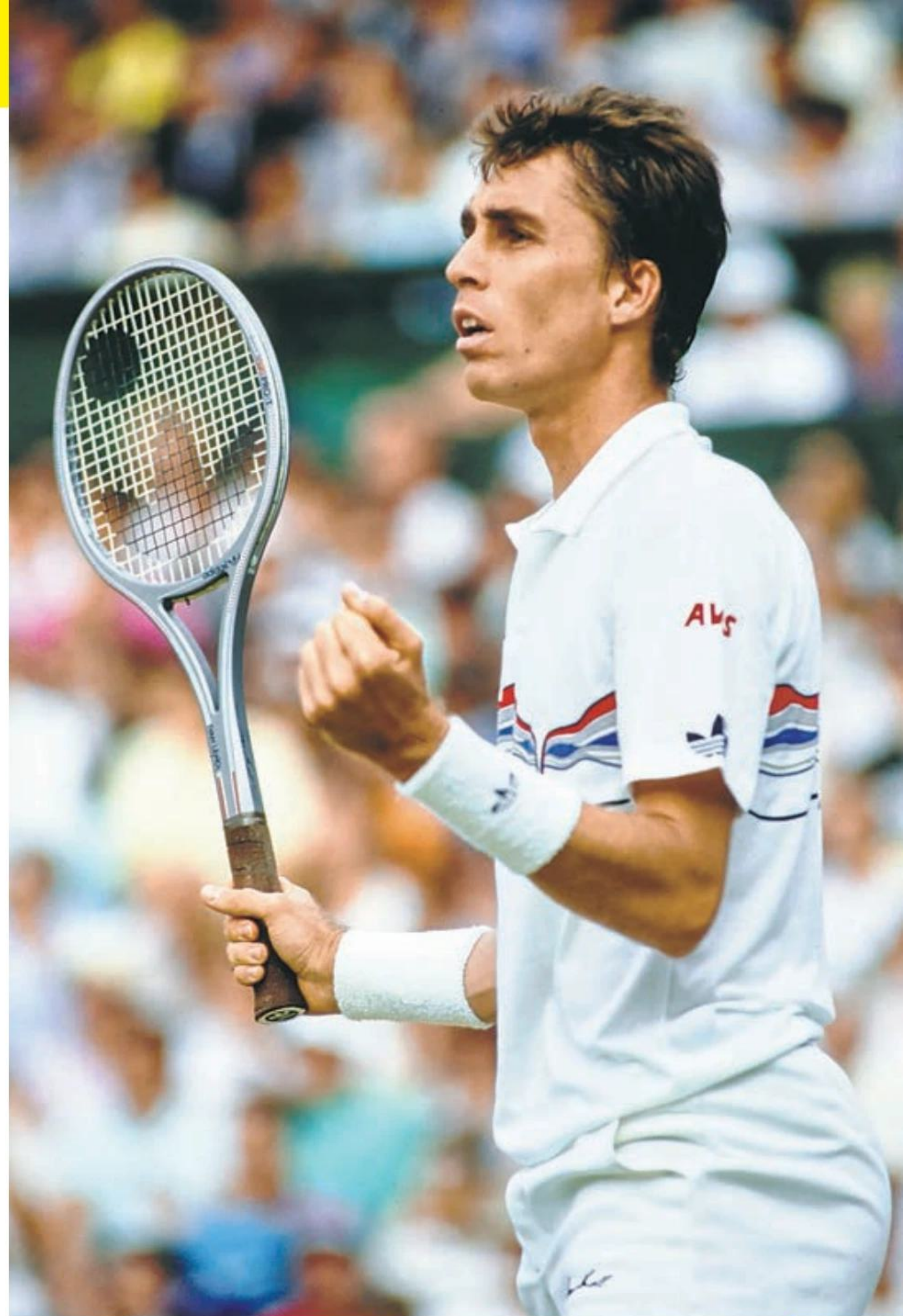




**Necessary transformation:** Martina Navratilova (left) turned into a muscular, super-fit 'bionic woman' while Ivan Lendl (right) became renowned for his insanely gruelling off-court training.

fitness fanatic, Ivan Lendl, was renowned for his insanely gruelling off-court training. Novak Djokovic, perhaps the most dedicated and knowledgeable champion in tennis history, often talks about his 'holistic' approach that includes hyperbaric oxygen chambers, 'pyramid water', and superfoods like goji berries, spirulina, and sea algae. No wonder *Men's Health* magazine's 2021 feature about the GOAT was titled — 'Is Novak Djokovic The Fittest Athlete of All Time?'

To learn more about the physiology of tennis athletes, I consulted Mackie Shilstone (**facing page, below**) one of America's most influential fitness, wellness, and sports performance experts. The New Orleans-based author of seven health and fitness books has played a pivotal role in the success and

longevity of more than 3,000 professional athletes and teams over the past 43 years. His most famous sports clients include Serena Williams, boxing champions Roy Jones Jr., Bernard Hopkins, and Michael Spinks, NFL Hall of Famers Peyton Manning and Morten Anderson, Hockey Hall of Famer Brett Hull, and baseball super-athlete Ozzie Smith. Serena won 14 of her Open Era-record 23 Grand Slam singles titles during Shilstone's 14-year stint.

**The sports ax'om that a good b'g man beats a good small man 's truer than ever 'n tenn's. The top 20 men averaged 5'9" 'n 1973, shot up to 6' 'n 1989, and now stands at 6'2.85". Close to that average are the legendary Big Three of 6'2" Novak Djokovic, 6'1" Rafael Nadal, and 6'1" Roger Federer as well as the**

new Big Two of 6'3" Jannik Sinner and 6' Carlos Alcaraz. In 2019, Reilly Opelka, a 6'11.75" American who upset Djokovic at Brisbane this January, told *The Telegraph (UK)* that "6'3" to 6'6" 's going to be the 'deal." The women's game has also trended taller. The top 20 now averages 5'8.6", and players 5'9" or taller have won n'ne of the last 10 Grand Slam t'tles and the Par's Olymp'cs. What 's the best he'ght or he'ght range for men and women pro players?

**Shilstone:** There isn't a single 'best' height for male and female tennis players, as success in the sport depends on a combination of factors, including skill, athleticism, strategy, and mental toughness. However, there are height ranges that tend to be more advantageous based on historical and current top players.